



Hurricanes

In the tropics, the intense heat evaporates vast quantities of ocean water. This builds up colossal cloud systems centered on a zone of very low air pressure. Air swirls into the low-pressure zone and sets the cloud mass spinning, creating a tropical revolving storm, or hurricane.

HURRICANE BELT

Hurricanes build up over tropical oceans with surface temperatures of 80°F (27°C) or more. They generally move west, driven by the tropical trade winds, until they hit land and veer off in a new direction. This satellite image shows Hurricane Irene approaching Florida in August 2011.

INSIDE A HURRICANE

At the core of a hurricane, very low pressure makes the surrounding air and storm clouds spiral inward. The wind speeds up as the spiral tightens. A strong updraft around the calm eye of the storm builds the tallest clouds, which produce heavy rain. They are topped by high cirrus clouds that spill out in the opposite direction.

► REVOLVING STORM

The main hurricane-force winds (red) spiral into the eye of the storm, which itself is calm. High-altitude winds (blue) spiral outward.

